

The Digital Canvas: Preserving Heritage & Empowering Futures (Andolo Gideon Youth Initiative)

1. Executive Summary

The "Digital Canvas" project seeks to empower the Andolo Gideon Youths by bridging the gap between traditional cultural expression and modern digital technology. Utilizing Meural's digital art platform, this initiative will transform the group from passive consumers of content into active creators and digital curators. By providing access to digital art tools and a high-quality display network, the project aims to foster digital literacy, preserve cultural heritage through storytelling, and create economic opportunities in the creative digital economy. The expected impact is a measurable increase in youth engagement, the preservation of Andolo Gideon oral history, and the development of marketable digital skills for 50+ youths.

2. Introduction/Problem Statement

The Andolo Gideon Youths represent a vibrant demographic brimming with potential, yet they face significant challenges common to many rural or semi-urban youth groups:

- **Limited Access to Technology:** There is a scarcity of platforms that allow youths to engage with art and storytelling in a contemporary, globally relevant format.
- **Cultural Erosion:** Traditional stories, customs, and artistic methods risk being lost as oral traditions struggle to compete with globalized digital media.
- **Skill Gaps:** While many youths possess creativity, they lack exposure to digital tools (digital illustration, content curation, videography) that are prerequisites for the modern creative economy.
- **Lack of Visibility:** The rich cultural heritage and artistic talent within the community lack a prestigious platform to be showcased to the local community, visitors, or potential patrons.

Without intervention, these youths risk being left behind economically and culturally. This project addresses the need for a creative hub that validates their identity while equipping them for the future.

3. Project Description

What is Meural?

Meural is a digital canvas that turns high-resolution screens into a platform for displaying art, photography, and video. In the context of this project, Meural serves three critical functions:

1. **A Gallery:** A rotating, high-definition exhibition space for youth-created art.
2. **A Storyteller:** A medium to display digital stories, short documentaries, and cultural animations that capture Andolo Gideon history.
3. **A Classroom:** A dynamic display for educational content, digital literacy tutorials, and creative software training.

Project Activities

The project will involve a cycle of creation, curation, and exhibition:

1. **Digital Art & Illustration Workshops:** Training youths in digital illustration and photography. Using the Meural canvas to display their work in real-time for peer critique.
2. **Cultural Archiving & Storytelling:** Youths will interview elders and record oral histories. These narratives will be transformed into visual stories (stop-motion, digital comics, or short films) and displayed on the Meural network.
3. **"Meet the Artist" Nights:** Monthly community gatherings where the Meural displays rotate through the month's best works, allowing youths to present their work to community leaders and potential sponsors.
4. **Skill-Building Exhibits:** Using the Meural to run tutorials on graphic design principles, coding basics, and entrepreneurship, creating a self-sustaining learning environment.

Target Audience

The primary audience is the Andolo Gideon Youths, a group of approximately 50-100 young individuals (ages 15-30) within the community. Secondary audiences include the wider community (who will view the displays) and local tourism/cultural institutions.

Project Goals & Objectives

- **Goal 1: Enhance Digital Literacy.**
 - *Objective:* Train 50 youths in basic digital art/curation software within the first 6 months.
- **Goal 2: Preserve Cultural Heritage.**
 - *Objective:* Digitally archive 20 unique Andolo Gideon stories or cultural practices by the end of the project cycle.
- **Goal 3: Create Economic Opportunities.**
 - *Objective:* Facilitate at least 3 youth-led commissions (e.g., logo design, event coverage) using skills acquired via the project.

- **Goal 4: Increase Visibility.**
 - *Objective:* Host 4 public exhibitions per year utilizing the Meural displays to showcase youth talent.

4. Methodology/Implementation Plan

Phase	Timeline	Activities	Key Personnel
Phase 1: Setup	Month 1-2	Procurement of Meural devices, installation at community center, procurement of tablets/laptops for creation.	Project Lead, Tech Specialist
Phase 2: Training	Month 3-5	Conduct foundational workshops: Photography, Digital Illustration (Procreate/Canva), and Video Editing.	External Trainer, Youth Ambassadors
Phase 3: Creation & Curation	Month 6-9	Youth begin digitizing stories. Peer-to-peer mentorship. First exhibition launch.	Youth Participants, Curator
Phase 4: Scaling & Sustainability	Month 10-12	Advanced workshops (monetization). Establishment of a youth-led "Media Committee" to manage the Meural post-funding.	Project Lead, Community Elders

5. Budget (in Kenyan Shillings)

Exchange rate used: 1 USD = 140 KES (approximate)

Item	Description	Quantity	Unit Cost (KES)	Total (KES)	Justification
Hardware					

Item	Description	Quantity	Unit Cost (KES)	Total (KES)	Justification
Meural Canvas (27" or 32")	High-res digital display for exhibition space	2	70,000	140,000	Core gallery units for community center.
Meural Membership	Subscription for unlimited uploads/features	2 years	21,000	42,000	Allows for unlimited curation and cloud storage.
Creative Tablets (e.g., iPad/Wacom)	Tools for youth to create digital art	5	42,000	210,000	Shared resources for training workshops.
Laptop/Desktop	For video editing and management	1	112,000	112,000	Admin and advanced editing station.
Software & Materials					
Creative Cloud Suite	Licenses for Photoshop, Premiere Pro	1 year	84,000	84,000	Essential for professional digital storytelling.
Printing/Exhibition Materials	Framing, banners for launch event	1	42,000	42,000	For the physical launch event.

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Personnel & Training					
Digital Art Facilitator	Professional trainer (3 months part-time)	1	140,000	140,000	Skill transfer to youth.
Stipends (Youth Ambassadors)	4 youths to assist with tech maintenance	12 months	7,000	336,000	Ensures ownership and accountability.
Operational					
Transportation & Logistics	Moving equipment, field visits for archiving	12 months	14,000	168,000	Necessary for capturing stories in the field.
Contingency	Unforeseen costs	5%		63,700	Risk management.
Total Request				1,337,700 KES	

6. Monitoring & Evaluation (M&E)

To ensure accountability and track progress, we will employ the following metrics:

- Quantitative Metrics:

- **Attendance:** Daily/weekly log of youth users interacting with the Meural and workshops (Target: 80% attendance rate).
- **Output:** Number of unique digital artworks/stories uploaded to the Meural platform (Target: 50 pieces/year).
- **Skill Assessment:** Pre- and post-training surveys measuring proficiency in digital tools (Target: 40% increase in self-reported confidence).
- **Qualitative Metrics:**
 - **Portfolio Reviews:** Quarterly review sessions where youths present their work to a panel of local leaders.
 - **Feedback Forms:** Monthly feedback from participants regarding the relevance and quality of the training.
 - **Community Impact:** Surveys conducted during public exhibitions to gauge community engagement and pride.

7. Sustainability Plan

The project is designed to outlast the initial funding cycle through the following strategies:

1. **Youth Tech Committee:** A rotating group of trained youths will be responsible for maintaining the Meural hardware, updating the digital displays, and training new members, ensuring peer-to-peer knowledge transfer.
2. **Service-Based Revenue:** The "Andolo Gideon Media" group will offer paid services to the community—such as digital memorials for families, wedding photography edits, or branding for local small businesses—using the project's equipment. 50% of these proceeds will fund a maintenance fund for the Meural, while 50% goes back to the youth creators.
3. **Local Sponsorship:** The rotating gallery space on the Meural can be leased to local businesses or tourism boards to display their advertisements or welcoming messages, generating a passive income stream for the youth group.

8. Organizational Background

The proposers are a coalition of community development advocates and tech educators with a deep connection to the Andolo Gideon community. Our team has over 10 years of combined experience in youth mentorship and arts education. We are not just seeking to install hardware; we are committed to a long-term partnership with the Andolo Gideon Youths to ensure that this technology serves as a tool for economic independence and cultural pride. We operate with a philosophy of "hand-up, not hand-out," ensuring that every dollar spent leads to a tangible skill gained.

9. Conclusion

The Andolo Gideon Youths stand at a crossroads of tradition and technology. By funding this proposal, you are not merely purchasing a digital canvas; you are investing in a platform for voices that are too often unheard. The Meural device will serve as a beacon—a place where heritage is preserved, creativity is celebrated, and skills are forged. We invite you to partner with us in empowering these youths to paint their future on a digital canvas that the world can see.

We respectfully request a funding allocation of KES 1,337,700 to turn this vision into reality.